

Infantry tank

A British and French concept developed in the interwar period. Infantry tanks were slow but well-armored vehicles that were deployed in support of infantry on foot. Once infantry tanks had broken through enemy lines, faster cruiser or light tanks were expected to penetrate deep into enemy territory.

Infrared

A type of light radiation that allows the perception of heat signals, among other things. It is useful for night vision and thermal imaging.

Kinetic-Energy (KE) projectile

A type of munition that relies on its own mass and motion (i.e. kinetic energy) for its destructive power. KE projectiles do not explode. Armor-piercing rounds are examples of KE projectiles, as are ordinary bullets.

L/x (Barrel length)

The length of a gun barrel expressed in multiples of its caliber. For example, the 120mm L/55 gun has a barrel length of 22 ft (6.6 m) or 6,600mm (120 x 55).

Landships committee

A British committee established by Winston Churchill, First Lord of the Admiralty, in 1915. Its purpose was to develop armored fighting vehicles, or “landships,” to break the stalemate on the Western Front. Its chief outcome was the invention of the tank.

Laser range finder

A means of calculating the range to a target by measuring the time taken for a laser pulse to be reflected off the target and return to the range finder. This has replaced previous methods of calculating range on AFVs.

Leaf-spring suspension

One of the oldest forms of suspension, leaf springs are still common on military vehicles. They are made of slender arcs of steel that are stacked and bound together, forming a springing mount on which a single axle rests.

Light reconnaissance car

A series of vehicles used by the British Reconnaissance Corps during World War II. Lightly armed and armored, they were based on commercial vehicle chassis.

Light tank

A thinly armored tank designed for rapid movement rather than aggressive combat power. Today, its role is largely confined to reconnaissance.

Line

A formation of tanks arranged side by side.

Loader

The tank crewman responsible for loading the main gun.

Machine gun

A weapon that uses the gas or recoil from its fired projectile to cycle its action and so give continuous automatic fire.

Main Battle Tank (MBT)

Otherwise known as a universal tank. MBTs are the mainstay of modern tank units, combining elements of their medium and heavy predecessors.

Main gun

A tank’s primary armament. Today, main guns are capable of firing kinetic-energy projectiles, high-explosive rounds, and even guided missiles.

Mantlet

A plate of armor that protects the area where a tank’s main gun projects from its turret. In order to fire the gun, this section cannot be concealed from the enemy, so it is often the thickest part of a tank’s armor.

Materiel

All the hardware needed by a military force to complete a specific mission—from ammunition to fighter jets, if needed.

Medium tank

A class of tank that is almost as mobile as a light tank and almost as protected as a heavy tank. Medium tanks came of age during World War II, but first saw service in World War I in the form of the British Medium Mark A “Whippet.”

Military logistics

The art of planning and executing the movement of military forces, from directing men and materiel to battlefields to setting up and maintaining supply chains.

Mine Resistant Ambush Protected (MRAP)

A class of vehicle designed as a response to the increasing use of IEDs in Iraq after the invasion of 2003. MRAPs use design features such as V-shaped hulls to protect against IED blasts, and are armored against direct fire attack.

Molotov cocktail

Originally an antitank weapon deployed by the Finns against the Soviets during World War II. It was little more than a bottle filled with gasoline with a lighted wick that was dropped into the hatches of Soviet tanks—a “gift” for the Soviet Foreign Minister Vyacheslav Molotov.

Multibank engine

An engine with a high number of cylinders arranged in multiple lines or banks.

Muzzle

The forward, open end of a gun’s barrel.

Muzzle brake

A device attached to the end of the barrel of a main gun to vent propellant gases and reduce recoil.

NATO

An acronym for the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, an international alliance of countries from North America and Western Europe originally formed in 1949 in opposition to the Soviet Union.

NBC

A term used to refer to Nuclear, Chemical, and Biological weaponry (commonly known as Weapons of Mass Destruction). The effects these weapons can have on a target require the use of specialized protection systems if personnel and equipment are to operate in areas where they have been used.

Optical range finder

A system that uses the operator’s eyesight and trigonometry to determine the distance to a target. Two prisms a known distance apart reflect images of the target into the eyepiece of the operator, who then adjusts the angle of the prisms until the two images appear as one. This angle is used to calculate the distance.

Ordnance

Weapons and ammunition, specifically artillery.

Organic

An organic military unit is an integral part of a larger formation, rather than being temporarily assigned to it for a specific mission.

Paraffin

A combustible hydrocarbon fuel, a derivation of which, JP8, is used to power several NATO tanks.

Platoon

A military unit, normally equivalent in size to the troop and consisting of around 30 soldiers or 3–5 tanks.

Pounder

The system used to identify British artillery and antitank rounds based on the weight of the projectile in pounds (1 lb = 0.454 kg). It fell out of use after World War II, and was replaced by caliber.

Radial engine

An engine configuration in which the cylinders are positioned in a circle, “radiating” out from a central crankcase.

Rate of fire

The number of rounds that can be fired by a given weapon, usually expressed in rounds per minute.

Reactive armor

A type of appliqué armor that reacts to incoming enemy projectiles to reduce the damage done to the vehicle. The most common type is Explosive Reactive Armor, which explodes when hit by a penetrating weapon, damaging the latter and dissipating its energy.

Regiment

A military unit whose nature varies depending on its country of origin. Some nations use the term for an operational unit of brigade or battalion size, others for a ceremonial or administrative unit that does not fight on the battlefield.

Return rollers

Small wheels located above a tank’s road wheels that keep the top of the caterpillar track running straight between the drive sprocket and the idler.

Rifling

An arrangement of spiral grooves within the barrel of a gun that imparts rotary motion to the fired projectile, which then travels through the air with greater accuracy.

Road wheels

The main wheels that rotate within the tracks of a tank. They are unpowered and serve only to distribute the tank’s weight.

Rocket-Propelled Grenade (RPG)

An infantry antitank rocket launcher, originally made by the Soviet Union. A large number of different models of RPG have been manufactured since the late 1940s, the most common being the RPG-7.

Scout car

A lightly armed and armored wheeled vehicle generally used for reconnaissance.

Scouting

The action of gathering information about an area or the disposition of enemy forces. Also known as reconnaissance.

Self-propelled gun

A mobile artillery piece, such as a howitzer, that is mounted on a motorized wheeled or tracked chassis.

Semiautomatic

A gun that will only fire one round when the trigger is pulled, but loads the next round automatically.

Shaped charge

An explosive charge shaped in order to focus the energy of its explosion in a particular direction, which enhances its effect. Shaped charges are used in HEAT rounds.

Shrapnel shell

An antipersonnel artillery munition, shrapnel shells were designed to explode in midair over enemy positions, showering the area with lethal balls of steel or lead. Since the end of World War I, shrapnel has been superseded by high-explosive shells, which produce both explosive blast and fragments on detonation.

Sloped armor

Armor that is sloped to give greater protection to a tank’s hull or turret. The angled surface helps deflect projectiles,